

CSS Pseudo-Class & Pseudo-Element — Quick Notes

1. Pseudo-Class (:)

Definition: A pseudo-class styles an element when it is in a particular **state or condition**, such as hover, visited, focus, or checked.

Syntax: `selector:pseudo-class { property: value; }`

Easy rule: `:` = STATE / CONDITION

Pseudo-class	Meaning	Example
<code>:link</code>	Unvisited link	<code>a:link { color: orange; }</code>
<code>:visited</code>	Link already visited	<code>a:visited { color: blue; }</code>
<code>:hover</code>	Mouse is over an element	<code>div:hover { color: red; }</code>
<code>:active</code>	Element is being clicked/activated	<code>button:active { color: green; }</code>
<code>:focus</code>	Input/element currently has focus	<code>input:focus { background: yellow; }</code>
<code>:checked</code>	Checkbox/radio is checked	<code>input:checked { width: 20px; }</code>
<code>:disabled</code>	Form element is disabled	<code>button:disabled { color: gray; }</code>
<code>:first-child</code>	First child of its parent	<code>p:first-child { color: red; }</code>
<code>:last-child</code>	Last child of its parent	<code>p:last-child { color: blue; }</code>
<code>:nth-child(2)</code>	Selects the second child	<code>p:nth-child(2) { color: red; }</code>
<code>:not()</code>	Selects elements that do not match	<code>p:not(.special) { color: red; }</code>

2. Pseudo-Element (::)

Definition: A pseudo-element styles or targets a **specific part** of an element, or inserts content before/after it.

Syntax: `selector::pseudo-element { property: value; }`

Easy rule: `::` = PART OF AN ELEMENT

Pseudo-element	Meaning	Example
<code>::first-letter</code>	Styles the first letter	<code>p::first-letter { color: red; font-size: 30px; }</code>
<code>::first-line</code>	Styles the first line	<code>p::first-line { color: blue; }</code>
<code>::selection</code>	Styles selected text	<code>p::selection { background-color: yellow; }</code>
<code>::before</code>	Inserts content before	<code>p::before { content: "★ "; }</code>
<code>::after</code>	Inserts content after	<code>p::after { content: " ✓"; }</code>

Quick Difference

Pseudo-class (:) → describes an element's **state/condition**.

Examples: **:hover**, **:visited**, **:focus**, **:checked**

Pseudo-element (::) → targets a **part of an element** or adds content.

Examples: **::first-letter**, **::first-line**, **::before**, **::after**